Goliath

By Simon Rich

NARRATOR: **(Pg 167-187)** Goliath looked down at the familiar crowd of reporters. The reporters were vigorously wiping down their slates to make room for his sound bites. Goliath couldn't help but feel a tiny surge of pride. He'd been fighting people to the death for years, and somehow everybody was still interested.

INTRODUCTION

ANNOUNCER'S VOICE: *Ladies and gentlemen . . . Children of all ages! Welcome to the Death Match!*
NORMAL VOICE: *We all know the story of David and Goliath. It's the ultimate underdog tale. The scrappy kid. The giant bully. One sling, one stone, one perfectly placed shot . . . and boom! Sunday school legend . . . But what if that's not* ***exactly*** *how it went down?*
ANNOUNCER's VOICE: *GOLIATH! Towering warrior! Divorced dad of a 12-year-old who needs private school. (beat) and . . .DAVID! Brave; marketable; relatable! He's got a fragrance line!*
NORMAL VOICE: *This is a story about fame, privilege, public opinion and what happens when history is written by whoever has the better manager.*
ANNOUNCER'S VOICE: *Because in this arena, the real weapon isn't a stone!*
NORMAL VOICE: *(whispers) It's publicity. (beat) Goliath by Simon Rich*

GOLIATH: *(calling on a reporter)* You have question for Goliath?

REPORTER: What are your thoughts on fighting David?

GOLIATH: *(unsure, scratching his beard)* Who is David?

DAVID: *(enters, floppy hair bouncing)* Wow, this is so cool! A real-life press conference! So how does this even ***work****?* Do I call on people ***myself****?* Wow! Okay, I guess I'll start with ... Shana.

SHANA: The question we all want to know is, what makes you believe that a small, poor, unarmed child can defeat a well-known giant in a death match?

DAVID: I'm just grateful for the opportunity to fight at all. Growing up small, poor, and unarmed, I never imagined I'd ever get the chance to do anything noteworthy. It's all thanks to my mom. Being a single mother is no joke. If you ask me, she's the ***real*** underdog death fighter.

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REPORTER: My question is about determination. Do you have it?

DAVID: *(commanding the room)* Great question. Yes.

GOLIATH: *(baffled he's not in the spotlight)* That was two in a row for David. Usually, one question for Goliath, one for other death fighter, then Goliath speak again.

REPORTER: Okay, I've got one: How impressed are you by David?

GOLIATH: *(confused)* David is boy. Goliath is giant. We should not even be fighting.

SHANA: *(solemnly, throwing a disapproving look at Goliath)* David, how would you respond to Goliath's hurtful statement?

DAVID: I ain't doing this for me. I'm doing it for all those kids in Bethlehem who get told every day of their lives, 'You'll never get to be a death fighter.' I'm fighting for Bethlehem, and D's always gonna rep the Beth, straight up. D's gonna be D. No fronting, no filter. Just some kid from the Beth, trying to shine. That's who I am. That's D.

GOLIATH: *(saddened that no one was paying attention to him)* Goliath hungry. Okay . . . Goliath go.

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NARRATOR: Goliath ate a full-size pig *(Goliath burps)* It had been a long, strange day, but now he was at peace, sitting across from his 12-year-old daughter, Jules.

JULES: *(in typical pre-teen giant fashion)* Mom says you need to call the school. Something about tuition . . .

NARRATOR: Middle school so far had not been easy. The other kids made fun of her for the tiniest of things: her height, her width, the depth of her voice, the fullness of her unibrow, the crash of her steps, the unsettlingly audible sound of her eyeblinks. *(Jules blinks awkwardly)* Private school had seemed like the only option. [But] Goliath was in serious trouble. Gretchen had gotten almost everything in the divorce. His death fights paid decently, and there were some incentives built into his contract, like if he won in the first round. Even if he managed [to defeat] David, he still wouldn't be able to cover Jules's tuition. His only hope was to find an additional source of income. Luckily, he knew just where to start.

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GOLIATH: *(taking a seat in Skeebo's office)* Goliath never do endorsement before . . .

SKEEBO: Neither had David when he met me. Now the kid's hot! Signature sandal, signature tunic. They took a drop of sweat to make a fragrance and it sold out in a day. Kid's got a production company, D Street, started as a vanity label for his raps, now the Saudis want to invest. *(beat)* Let's get into it. I asked around town, put out a bunch of feelers with all kinds of brands. Unfortunately, there are no offers.

GOLIATH: *(shaking his head in disbelief)* Why not?

SKEEBO: The brands all want David. Do you realize he's gotten so popular that people are naming their *kids* after him? No joke. 'David' is becoming, like, a normal, common name.

GOLIATH: Why don't people like Goliath? Goliath has been winning for years.

SKEEBO: That's the problem. Audiences just don't find you appealing. They see David as way more authentic, root-able, and likable.

NARRATOR: Goliath growled in frustration. *(Goliath growls)* He understood why people sympathized with David. He was small and about to be murdered. But it's not like Goliath had it easy. If the public knew the pressure he was under, then surely their allegiances would change.

GOLIATH: Goliath will get endorsements. Goliath just need to show people real Goliath.

******* Shanna's Talk Show*****

SHANA: My next guest is an undefeated death fighter who has represented Philistine for years. His next match will be against David, who represents everybody here as well as the one true God. Goliath, thanks for being with us . . . I understand there's something you would like to clear up.

GOLIATH: *(clearing his throat, he has obviously prepared)* People think Goliath have it easy. But really Goliath have things hard. *(to audience earnestly)* When Goliath was young, Goliath had to eat more food than other kids. Sometimes Goliath would have to sit at table 20 minutes longer than everybody else. So there is that. Also, it is not easy killing people. Sometimes, blood splashes onto Goliath's clothes and it is wet. And number three: it is hard

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for Goliath to buy pants. In conclusion: Goliath history's greatest victim.

AUDIENCE: Boo!

SHANA: Forgive me for being skeptical, because when I look at you, I don't see hardship. What I see, frankly, is a lot of privilege.

GOLAITH: *(quick with a denial, he pleads to the audience)* People think Goliath is rich, but Goliath is not rich. If you do not start worshipping Goliath, Goliath will not score cushy endorsement deals, and he will not even be able to send daughter to private school! He will have to send her to public school with poor people! People as poor as you!

AUDIENCE: *(even louder and throwing sand)* Boo!

NARRATOR: The truth was that other people decided who you were, and once they did you could never change their minds.

****** The Day of the Death Match*******

(sound effects of trumpets blaring to announce the match)

GOLIATH: *(flexing for the audience)* Goliath have message for haters! Your beloved David is about to die! And not in a normal way! Think of craziest way you can think of! It will be crazier than that!

NARRATOR: Goliath rarely spoke before his fights, preferring to let his killing do the talking, but this time he'd screamed himself hoarse. And by the time he climbed into the ring, it was obvious his taunts had made an impact. David's normally buoyant blond bob lay flat on his head, matted down by sweat, and his bright blue eyes looked bloodshot.

DAVID: *(calling to his manager)* Yo Skeebo! Maybe we should postpone? *(frantic breathing)*

GOLIATH: *(cracking his neck and stretching, he points at David)* Goliath kill you soon!

DAVID: *(fumbling for his slingshot, it wobbles in his hands as he slides in a pebble and feebly draws it back)*

NARRATOR: The crowd fell silent; they knew this shot would be David's one chance.

GOLAITH: *(in slow motion, watches as the stone drifts toward him)*

NARRATOR: He thought about the trophies he had won, the belts he had hoisted. He thought about the way it felt to win a fight, the unmatchable clarity that could come only with

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victory, that sense, however fleeting, that you had been born for a reason. So far, his fights had all been easy. This one would be hard.

GOLIATH: *(takes a deep breath as the pebble bounces harmlessly off his brow, then in an epic overacting flop . . .)* Ow! Goliath lose death fight! *(he staggers to the ground)*

NARRATOR: He knew it wasn't the kind of performance that would have passed muster in theater club, but the crowd seemed to buy it, screaming and crying in ecstasy.

DAVID: *(celebrating his win)* Yeah, bruh! All day!

NARRATOR: Goliath kept his eyes closed until the cheering faded into silence. When he finally opened them, Skeebo was smiling down at him, holding a sack of silver pieces. Their deal had been simple. In exchange for the dive, Goliath would receive an anonymous stake in D Street Productions going forward. As long as David's star continued to rise-and it assuredly would after this upset-Goliath could cover Jules's tuition indefinitely.

SKEEBO: *(Holding payment out of reach as Goliath gleefully reaches for his payment)* Hold up! You still gotta sign an NDA.

GOLIATH: What is NDA?

SKEEBO: *(looks over his shoulder then whispers ominously)* It means you can never tell anyone what happened here. Not the public, not the press, not David. Not even your own family!

NARRATOR: For the first time, Goliath pondered the full scope of what he had agreed to. This battle was the kind of thing people might remember. It was possible the public would even embellish his loss over the years, saying he'd died in the fight, or that David had cut off his head. Even Jules would grow up thinking he'd been beaten. His legacy of greatness would end, and instead, he would become a reference point for failure, an eternal symbol of humiliation. . .

GOLAITH: *(contemplates for a moment, shrugs then signs with a flourish and grabs the cash; then to audience proudly, tapping his brow)* Goliath have smarter idea. *(winks)*

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AWARD HISTORY

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